Himaayah Schools
SKILLS SCHOOL

FREE GUIDE

إِنَّ خَيْرَ مَنِ اسْتَأْجَرْتَ الْقَوِيُّ الْأَمِينُ

"The best one you can hire is the strong, the trustworthy." (al-Qaṣaṣ 28:26)

Your First CV and Interview

Write a clear one-page CV, a short cover letter, and prepare for the questions every interviewer asks.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Whether you are applying for a holiday job, an internship, a scholarship, NYSC placement or your first full-time role, two things decide most first impressions: your **CV** and your **interview**. Many young people are turned down not because they lack ability, but because their CV is unclear or they were not prepared to speak about themselves.

This guide shows you how to write a clear one-page CV even with little experience, how to write a short cover letter, how to prepare for an interview, how to answer the most common questions, and how to follow up. It includes a CV template, sample answers and a checklist.

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>
> **“Indeed, the best one you can hire is the strong, the trustworthy.”**
>
> Al-Qaṣaṣ 28:26, said of Mūsā (ʿalayhi as-salām).

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Part 1 What a CV is for

A CV (curriculum vitae, or résumé) is a short document that shows an employer **why you are worth interviewing**. Recruiters often look at a CV for only a few seconds at first, so it must be clear, short and relevant. Like the verse above, they look for two things: **ability** (can you do the work?) and **trustworthiness** (can we rely on you?).

Part 2 The sections of a CV

Section	What to include
Name and contact	Full name, phone, a professional email (firstname.lastname@...), city, and a LinkedIn link if you have one. No need for your full home address.
Profile (2–3 lines)	Who you are, your key strengths and what you are looking for.
Education	Most recent first: school, qualification, dates, and grades if strong (e.g. WAEC results, CGPA).
Experience	Jobs, internships, volunteering, leadership roles, with dates and 2–3 achievements each.
Skills	Practical skills: Microsoft Office, Canva, languages, customer service, typing speed.
Achievements and activities	Awards, competitions, clubs, Qur'an memorisation, projects.
References	"Available on request", or one or two names with permission.

A one-page CV template

AMINAH BELLO · 0803 000 0000 · aminah.bello@email.com · Ibadan

Profile: A hard-working secondary school graduate with strong communication and computer skills, seeking an administrative internship.

Education: ABC College, Ibadan · WASSCE, 2026 · 7 credits including English and Mathematics.

Experience: Volunteer, Masjid Youth Programme (2024–2026): organised weekly classes for 40 children; managed the WhatsApp group and attendance.

Skills: Microsoft Word and Excel · Canva · Typing 45 words per minute · English and Yoruba.

Achievements: 2nd place, State Quiz Competition (2025) · Memorised 10 juz of the Qur'an.

References: Available on request.

Part 3 Writing with little experience

Everyone starts with no job history. Use what you have done, and write it as **action and result**:

Weak	Strong
Member of the press club.	Wrote and edited 6 articles for the school magazine, read by 800 students.
Helped in my mother's shop.	Served customers and recorded daily sales in a notebook for 2 years; handled up to ₦50,000 a day.
Good at computers.	Designed 20 flyers in Canva for school and masjid events.
Class captain.	Led a class of 45 students; organised a cleaning rota and reported to teachers weekly.

- Start each line with a strong verb: organised, led, designed, managed, taught, sold, improved.
- Add numbers where you can: how many, how much, how often.
- Match your CV to each job: put the most relevant experience and skills first.

Part 4 Mistakes to avoid

Mistake	Instead
Two or more pages for a first CV	One clear page
An unprofessional email (coolboy2009@...)	firstname.lastname@...
Spelling and grammar errors	Proofread, and ask someone else to check
Unnecessary personal details: religion, state of origin, marital status, a full-body photo	Include only what the job needs; many employers do not need these
Fancy colours and hard-to-read fonts	A clean layout and one readable font
Sending a Word file that changes on another computer	Send a PDF, named "Aminah Bello CV.pdf"

Part 5 The cover letter

A cover letter or application email is a short note that introduces your CV. Keep it to three short paragraphs:

Template

Dear Mr Okafor,

I am writing to apply for the **Administrative Intern** role advertised on your website. I recently completed my WASSCE at ABC College and I am keen to build a career in office administration.

In my role as a volunteer at our masjid youth programme, I organised weekly classes for 40 children and managed all communication and attendance records. I am confident with Microsoft Word, Excel and Canva, and I work carefully and on time.

I have attached my CV and would welcome the chance to discuss how I can help your team. Thank you for your time.

Yours sincerely, Aminah Bello · 0803 000 0000

Part 6 Preparing for the interview

When	What to do
Before	Research the organisation: what it does, its products, its values. Re-read the job description and your CV. Prepare answers and two questions to ask. Plan your route and leave early; for online interviews, test your internet, camera and a quiet room.
On the day	Dress neatly and modestly, as for a formal occasion. Arrive 10–15 minutes early. Bring copies of your CV and certificates. Greet everyone politely, including the receptionist.
During	Listen to the whole question, pause, then answer clearly. Keep answers to about one or two minutes. Be honest; if you don't know, say so and say how you would find out.
After	Send a short thank-you email the same day. If you hear nothing after the time they gave, follow up once politely.

Part 7 Common questions and how to answer

For questions about experience, use the **STAR** method: **S**ituation, **T**ask, **A**ction, **R**esult.

Question	A good approach
“Tell me about yourself.”	Two minutes: your education, one or two relevant experiences, your strengths, and why you want this role. Not your life story.
“Why do you want to work here?”	Show you researched them: mention what they do and how it matches your goals and skills.
“What are your strengths?”	Name two or three that fit the job, each with a quick example.
“What is your weakness?”	A real but minor weakness, and what you are doing to improve it.
“Tell me about a challenge you faced.”	Use STAR. Focus on what you did and what you learned.
“Where do you see yourself in five years?”	Show ambition that fits the organisation: growing skills and responsibility.
“Do you have any questions for us?”	Always say yes: “What does a typical day look like?” or “How will my performance be measured?”

A STAR example

Situation: At our masjid youth programme, attendance had dropped to 15 children. **Task:** I was asked to bring it back up. **Action:** I created a WhatsApp group for parents, sent weekly reminders and designed flyers. **Result:** Within two months, attendance rose to 40.

Part 8 Honesty and adab

- **Never lie** on a CV: no invented grades, jobs or certificates. It is ḥarām, and employers do check. “Whoever cheats is not of us” (Muslim, 102).
- **Keep your promises**: if you accept an interview, attend or cancel in advance.
- **Pray and prepare**: make duʿāʾ and istikhārah, then do your best and trust Allah with the result.
- **Rejection is not failure**: every interview is practice. Ask for feedback and apply again.

Checklist My checklist

Done	Step
☐	My CV fits on one page and uses action verbs and numbers.
☐	I have a professional email address.
☐	Someone has proofread my CV.
☐	I saved it as a PDF with my name.
☐	I wrote a short cover letter for this job.
☐	I researched the organisation and prepared answers using STAR.
☐	I have two questions to ask the interviewer.

☐	I know the route, the time and what to wear.
☐	I sent a thank-you email after the interview.

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. **A first CV should usually be:**
   a) One page b) Five pages c) Handwritten d) As long as possible

2. **STAR stands for:**
   a) Start, Talk, Answer, Repeat b) Situation, Task, Action, Result c) Skills, Training, Ability, Reference d) Smile, Thank, Ask, Return

3. **Which CV line is strongest?**
   a) Good at computers b) Designed 20 flyers in Canva for school events c) I like computers d) Computer

4. **The best file format to send a CV is usually:**
   a) PDF b) A photo c) A voice note d) An Excel file

5. **After the interview, you should:**
   a) Call every hour b) Send a short thank-you email c) Do nothing ever d) Post about it online

6. **In al-Qaṣaṣ 28:26, the best one to hire is:**
   a) The richest b) The strong and trustworthy c) The oldest d) The loudest

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	a) One page	4	a) PDF
2	b) Situation, Task, Action, Result	5	b) Send a thank-you email
3	b) Designed 20 flyers…	6	b) The strong and trustworthy

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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Show them you are strong and trustworthy.

This free guide from the Himaayah Skills School helps students and graduates apply for jobs, internships and scholarships with confidence.

- The sections of a CV, with a one-page template
- Writing a CV with little experience
- A short cover letter template
- Common interview questions and the STAR method
- Honesty, adab and a checklist

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